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THE REPUBLIC OF LIBERIA

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Marine Advisory: 29/2025
(This Marine Advisory cancels MA 28/2023)

Subject: Guideline for the prevention of collision between merchant vessels and fishing vessels in coastal waters of China

Dear Shipowner/Operator/Master:

The purpose of this Marine Advisory is to inform shipowners, operators and masters of the Guideline for the prevention of collision between merchant vessels and fishing vessels in coastal waters of China recently issued by the MSA. The objective of the Guideline is to provide guidance on collision prevention and to improve the collision risk control capabilities of both merchant and fishing vessels. All crew members responsible for navigation watch-keeping should possess a thorough understanding of the Guideline.

Update on Fishing Activities and Navigational Safety

Fishing activities along China's coastline partially resumed in August, and from 16 September 2025, the fishing season will recommence on a full scale. Consequently, traffic density in China's coastal waters is expected to rise significantly, with large numbers of fishing vessels departing from ports. This surge will exert considerable pressure on navigational safety.

To ensure safe navigation during this period, China MSA has updated the *Safety Advisories for Vessels Navigating China's Coastal Waters* (see attachment).

Shipowners, operators, and masters are hereby advised to:

- Circulate the updated Advisories to vessels flying the Liberian flag and to the relevant shipping companies;
- Incorporate the Advisories into company notices to ships, or update previous notices where necessary;
- Emphasize to master's and deck officers the importance of strict watchkeeping and collision-prevention measures in these complex traffic conditions; and
- Strengthen crew preparedness through targeted training and awareness initiatives.

By doing so, seafarers' awareness of the heightened risks will be raised, collision-prevention readiness strengthened, and safer navigation in China's coastal waters ensured.

Requirements

This Guideline incorporates the requirements of the International Regulations for Preventing Collisions at Sea 1972 Convention, as well as the navigation and fishing practices specific to the coastal waters of China and takes into consideration practical experiences of shipping

companies, industry associations and maritime institutions. The Guideline offers recommendations to optimize navigation techniques, regulate action to avoid collision, and address emergency rescue measures for merchant vessels navigating in the coastal waters of China.

1. Navigation Techniques

Prior to voyages bound for Chinese ports or transiting through coastal waters of China, special attention should be paid to the spatial distribution of fishing grounds. Voyage plans should consider the clusters of fishing vessels and avoid such clusters rather than taking unnecessary risks. If entry into waters with high concentrations of fishing vessels is unavoidable, proper identification of fishing vessels, their lights, shapes, and nets, as well as their ongoing fishing operations should be part of a collision avoidance plan. The Guideline also includes recommendations for the following scenarios:

- 1.1 Prior to entering areas with high concentrations of fishing vessels.
- 1.2 Navigating in or close to areas with high concentrations of fishing vessels.
- 1.3 Matters requiring special attention, such as season of the year, time of navigation, interference of AIS transmitters on fishing nets, among others.

2. Action to Avoid Collision

The Guideline describes specific actions to be taken such as the VHF channel to be used, the use of lights and whistles, reduction of speed, enhancement of lookout, among others.

3. Emergency Rescue

If the collision becomes unavoidable, the recommended actions include making the maximum effort to avoid a collision between the bow of merchant vessel and the side of the fishing vessel, the vessel should be brought to an immediate stop, promptly report the incident to the nearest competent maritime authority, among others.

If you have any questions, please contact our Fleet Performance Department at Telephone: +1-703-790-3434 or by email to prevention@liscr.com.

Safety Advisories for Vessels Navigating China's Coastal Waters

Since the opening of the 2025 fishing season, there has been an increase in collisions and near-miss incidents between merchant and fishing vessels in China's coastal waters. Risks have become more prominent. To prevent incidents and ensure navigation safety, the following advisories are issued:

1. Enhance Collision Prevention Training for Merchant and Fishing Vessels. Through channels such as ship agents, extensively gather accident prevention information including high-risk warning areas for collisions between commercial and fishing vessels, and operational characteristics of fishing vessels. Urge all crew members to study relevant documents such as "Guidelines for the Prevention of Collision Between Merchant Vessels and Fishing Vessels in China's Coastal Waters" and "Safety Notice for Preventing Collisions between Commercial and Fishing Vessels". Crew members must fully understand these high-risk areas and best practices for preventing collisions between merchants and fishing vessels.

2. Develop Scientific Navigational Plans. Given the current season of frequent typhoons and strong convective storms, fishing vessels tend to frequently enter and leave ports in large numbers due to adverse weather conditions. Please urge vessels to strengthen their safety risk assessment for each voyage, based on the safety information released by China MSA. Develop scientific navigational plans and collision prevention measures and use recommended routes and main public routes in China whenever possible. Avoid traffic flows where fishing vessels are concentrated during port entry and exit.

3. Conduct Safety Inspections of Critical Equipment Onboard. Please urge all vessels to inspect and test the following systems and devices: main engine, auxiliary engine, steering gear, windlass, boiler, radar, electronic chart, AIS, VDR, VHF, as well as navigation lights, daytime signal lights, and other sound signal equipment. Ensure all systems are in good working order and readily available for immediate use.

4. Strictly Enforce Watchkeeping Requirements. Please urge vessels to switch autopilot to manual steering when navigating in areas with dense fishing boats, maintain a proper lookout with at least two persons on watch. Whenever condition permits, try to maintain a distance of at least 1 nautical mile and remain alert. During navigation, vessels encountering fishing vessels that are unresponsive on VHF calls or have unclear movements must take proactive avoiding actions, following the principle of "early, substantial, wide, and clear." For newly appointed masters or those navigating China's coastal waters for the first time, special safety advisories must be provided with consideration of the specific characteristics of fishing vessels in these areas.

5. Enhance Emergency Training and Drills. Please organize vessels to conduct maintenance and operation training of facilities and equipment for man overboard and vessel abandon procedures, thereby effectively enhance the crew's self-rescue and mutual-rescue capabilities in emergencies. In the event of an emergency at sea, vessels must, while ensuring their own safety, actively engage in rescue operations and report to the local Maritime Rescue Coordination Center promptly.